

draw his or her own line, and the PE investor that is willing to bet on you. For the young unicorns, the PE [investor] is betting on individuals who will have the energy to turn the value that they give into even higher values. And in today's world, India is getting a very nice share of the wallet from the world of private equity.

You take a promoter like Ronnie, who has been successful time and again, and he has basically been able to create these incredibly valuable institutions and companies, so people are betting on him and the young people that he's working with. If they provide the value, then they expect an exit, for that's the rule of the game—if you want a value which is great, give me an exit that is greater.

And so that cycle and that merry-go-round goes on but I think that PE is immensely important and valuable to the country because it has allowed the world to recognise our companies. And it has put a value on our companies that didn't exist 10 years ago. So, today when you see our mid-sized companies, not necessarily our listed ones, these young entrepreneurs getting access to this money can only be good. And if the exit is something the PE asks for, you negotiate it, you get the best deal you can. That's the price of the money.

Q: I also want to ask you about some of the big deals which are happening in the disinvestment landscape. What kind of legal bedrock is important to get these transactions done in your eyes? Because, on one hand, you try to sell a BPCL and on the other hand, you freeze retail prices of fuel for months leading to huge losses. Do you think some of this legal provisioning needs to be in place to be able to attract high quality bidders for some of the government assets?

A: The government was pretty smart in the Air India deal where we represented Tata. Ultimately, the government to my mind behaved like a private

ON PRIVATE EQUITY

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ON PROMOTERS TRYING TO FIND A WAY AROUND LAWS

There are CEOs who, over the last 10 years, have recognised that trying to skirt the law or be over cute... is not productive because when the regulator comes after you, you have to answer for all that cuteness.

ON BEING A YOUNG LAWYER NOW

It is one of the most fascinating periods for any young lawyer—to be part of the entire development of corporate M&A, and of legal jurisprudence.

ON JUDICIAL ACTIVISM

It keeps all three branches [of a democracy] in check, reminding each that they are accountable for their behaviour.

party transacting. So, if the entire debt burden would not have been taken over by a good bidder, they dealt with that. When it came to unions and employees, they dealt with that. So, I think the disinvestment arm of the government has finally figured that for the best value, they've got to offer an attractive deal. So, when you are talking about BPCL, if the losses continue and the deregulation issue and the pricing does not get resolved, the government is simply not going to get a good price.

Q: I also want to ask where you stand on this whole controversy brewing in Karnataka, with the high court upholding the ban on hijab in colleges. If you were part of this case, what would your contention be on a matter which has struck such a national chord?

A: My personal view is that religion is such a personal aspect of one's daily life, that to intrude beyond a point is always counter-productive.

Any ill will is not as important as the feeling of security that you need in a population of this size. This has to be resolved in a way where communities don't feel scared and think of leaving the country. They shouldn't feel they aren't part of the motherland. So, the Supreme Court will resolve it, I'm sure.

Q: Finally, having worked with so many top industrialists over the last couple of decades, if you were to single out one or two people who really struck you as men of impeccable integrity, who would those be?

A: My few interactions with Mr Ratan Tata have all been fantastic; always clear-headed and the constant refrain was always, what was the right thing we should do? I think that has been the DNA of the group for as long as I can remember.

There are other business houses which have been absolutely exciting to work with, just for their sheer intellectual brilliance and their execution capability. But I would still say that if I have a fondness for one group, it would be the House of Tata. **BT**